

Cut From the Top

ADAP and Canada's 2025 disability-poverty record

In May 2026 the Government of Alberta described the new Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP) as offering a core benefit among the highest in the country. This brief tests that claim against the most recent national record — the Disability Poverty Report Card 2025, published by Campaign 2000 and Disability Without Poverty, drawing on Statistics Canada's Canadian Income Survey and Maytree's Welfare in Canada series. The documented record establishes that Alberta is moving roughly 50,000 disability recipients off the highest disability income of any province in the country, onto a permanent rate that falls below the deep-poverty line in both Calgary and Edmonton.

The claim

The Government of Alberta's May 12, 2026 ADAP fact sheet states that ADAP's core benefit of \$1,740 a month is among the highest in the country, providing about \$300 more per month than most disability programs in Canada. Measured only against other provinces, the comparison is roughly accurate: most provincial disability programs pay a single recipient below \$1,500 a month, so a \$1,740 rate does sit a few hundred dollars above the provincial median. The difficulty is not the arithmetic. It is what the comparison leaves out.

What the national record shows

The Disability Poverty Report Card 2025 sets out the disability income available to a single, unattached recipient in every province and territory. Among the provinces, the highest was Alberta's AISH, at approximately \$1,978 a month once federal and provincial credits are included.

Disability income, single recipient (2024, all-in)	Per month
Alberta — AISH	\$1,978
Newfoundland and Labrador	\$1,759
Prince Edward Island	\$1,692
British Columbia	\$1,654
Ontario	\$1,486
Quebec	\$1,422
New Brunswick	\$1,178

Alberta — ADAP (permanent core benefit) ***\$1,740**

* Provincial figures are all-in totals for 2024 (basic and additional assistance plus federal and provincial credits). The ADAP figure is the core benefit announced for July 2026, before credits; with the same credits that lift AISH's base to its all-in total, ADAP's all-in figure is roughly \$1,780.

The report card further finds that every one of the twelve provincial disability programs paid a single recipient below the official poverty line, and that nine of the twelve left that recipient in deep poverty — below 75 percent of the Market Basket Measure. Only two provincial programs lifted a single recipient clearly above the deep-poverty line: Alberta's AISH and Newfoundland and Labrador's. Prince Edward Island's sat exactly on it.

This is what the government's comparison omits. When ADAP is described as paying more than most disability programs in Canada, it is being measured against programs that the same national data identifies as leaving recipients in deep poverty. The relevant comparison for the roughly 50,000 Albertans being moved is not ADAP against Ontario or British Columbia. It is ADAP against the AISH they already receive — and AISH was the highest provincial disability income in the country.

The number that matters

The report card defines deep poverty as income below 75 percent of the Market Basket Measure, Canada's official poverty line. For a single person on the 2023 thresholds, that deep-poverty line works out to about \$1,792 a month in Edmonton and about \$1,810 a month in Calgary.

THE NUMBER THAT MATTERS: THE DEEP-POVERTY LINE

Single-person deep-poverty line (75% of the Market Basket Measure, 2023): Edmonton ~\$1,792 / month • Calgary ~\$1,810 / month

ADAP permanent core benefit: \$1,740 / month — below both

AISH, all-in (2024): \$1,978 / month — above the line

A \$200 transition top-up holds movers at the AISH level until December 31, 2027. After that date the permanent rate applies, and the 2027 poverty line will be higher than the 2023 figures shown here — widening the shortfall, not closing it.

ADAP's permanent core benefit is \$1,740 a month — below both city thresholds. The modest federal credits a recipient also receives do not close the gap: an all-in ADAP income of roughly \$1,780 still falls short of the deep-poverty line in Edmonton and Calgary. The federal Canada Disability Benefit, which might otherwise have offset the shortfall, is clawed back in Alberta — the report card records that Alberta was the only jurisdiction that had not committed to protecting it. A \$200 monthly transition top-up holds movers at their current AISH level until December 31, 2027; after that date the permanent rate applies.

Alberta was leading. This reverses it.

The same national record shows that Alberta had the lowest working-age disability-poverty rate of any province in 2023, at 12.8 percent, and the largest single-year reduction in the country: a three-percentage-point fall representing roughly 23,000 working-age Albertans with disabilities lifted out of poverty between 2022 and 2023. The program responsible for that standing is AISH — the highest provincial disability income in the country, and one of only two that cleared deep poverty. ADAP moves roughly 50,000 of those recipients onto a lower permanent rate. The documented record establishes that Alberta is dismantling the program that produced its national-leading result.

The couple penalty the country is warned against — and Alberta is building

The report card identifies household-based benefit rules as a documented harm. It records that disabled people across the country are penalized for living with a partner, that household-income rules assume shared resources that often do not exist, and that such rules force people to choose between intimacy and survival. Its recommendation is explicit: base disability benefits on individual income, not household income. Alberta's response, effective the August 2026 benefit period, is the opposite. Under the new cohabitation rule, two adults receiving disability income assistance who live together will each receive 88 percent of the maximum individual benefit. The national record names the harm; Alberta is writing it into regulation.

The employment premise, against the barrier data

ADAP is built on the premise that many disability recipients can be supported into the labour market. The national record documents the barrier that premise must overcome. In 2024, nearly three in five people with disabilities — 59 percent — encountered a labour-market accessibility barrier. People with disabilities had a labour-force participation rate of 69 percent against 82 percent for others, and an employment rate of 63 percent against 78 percent. The report card is direct about the cause: people with severe disabilities are often shut out of work not for lack of ability or willingness, but because hiring, workplaces, and accommodation systems are built to value productivity over inclusion. ADAP's employment exemptions assume an open door; the national data describes a structural one.

The bottom line

The Government of Alberta calls ADAP's benefit among the highest in the country. The national record establishes that the program ADAP replaces — AISH — was the highest provincial disability income in the country, and one of only two that lifted a single recipient clear of deep poverty. ADAP's permanent rate is lower than AISH, below the deep-poverty line in Calgary and Edmonton, and arrives with the federal benefit that might have offset it clawed back. Roughly 50,000 Albertans are being moved off the program that gave the province its national-leading result, onto a rate that the country's own poverty measure places in deep poverty. The contradiction stands on the public record.

Sources

Disability Poverty Report Card 2025: Too Little for Too Few — Ending Disability Poverty in Canada. Campaign 2000 and Disability Without Poverty, 2025. Drawing on Statistics Canada, Canadian Income Survey (2023), and Maytree, Welfare in Canada (2024).

Alberta Disability Assistance Program fact sheet. Government of Alberta, Assisted Living and Social Services, May 12, 2026.

Market Basket Measure thresholds, 2023: Statistics Canada, Table 11-10-0066-01 (2018-base).

Deep-poverty calculation: 75 percent of the single-person MBM threshold for Edmonton (\$28,671/year) and Calgary (\$28,955/year), expressed monthly. Provincial income figures: Report Card 2025, Table 2 (Maytree, Welfare in Canada, 2024).